

humiliating women, the rebels, armed with bows and arrows, destroyed rail lines, stations, and bridge works. British retaliation was swift, and troops wielding firearms were brought in on trains to quell the rebellion. About 20,000 Santhals were killed.

Rebel soldiers

By 1857, about 440 km of lines were already in operation. The British used them to move troops and supplies. The “revolt” had a greater effect on the railways. The rebels saw them as a soft target, and destroyed lines. Railway engineers working in remote areas volunteered to fight against the rebels, helped to fortify defences, or found themselves hiding.

The Illustrated London News reported one such incident that occurred in Barwarie near Allahabad in June 1857, when a group of railway engineers and contractors took refuge in a water tank at a railway station. They held off a mob of 3,000 people who threw brickbats and stones at them after looting and burning a bungalow that belonged to contractors Messrs Morris and Company. Soldiers from the 35 Irregular Cavalry, dispatched from Allahabad Fort, finally rescued them after an ordeal of 32 hours.

“Little House at Arrah”

One of the most famous stand-offs during this period was between railway engineers and the armed rebels at Arrah in Bihar. Railway work was still on between Dinapore and Arrah, as was the construction of a bridge over the River Sone. The resident engineer Richard Vicars Boyle took the reports of unrest quite seriously. He fortified a building in his garden (originally meant to be a billiards room), bricked up the verandah, and stocked it with provisions and arms.

In July 1857, the Dinapore regiments mutinied and marched towards Arrah, plundering and destroying everything along the way. Chief engineer Edward Davidson wrote in *The Railways of India, with an Account of Their Rise, Progress, and Construction* that the resident engineers, inspectors, overseers, and their families managed to escape in iron boats belonging to the railway company.